

SCULPTOR

THE SCULPTOR

FAINT AND UNREMARKABLE, SCULPTOR IS EASY TO FIND BECAUSE IT LIES DIRECTLY TO THE EAST OF THE BRIGHT STAR FOMALHAUT IN PISCIS AUSTRINUS. IT IS HOME TO SEVERAL INTERESTING GALAXIES.

Sculptor was introduced to the sky by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille in 1754. Originally named Apparatus Sculptoris (the sculptor's studio), it depicts a marble head, mallet, and chisel on a stand. However, the star pattern is more reminiscent of a shepherd's crook. None of the stars is named, and all are 4th magnitude or fainter. It contains the Sculptor Group, a cluster of about a dozen galaxies, one of the nearest to our own Local Group. At the Group's heart is NGC 253, discovered by German-born English astronomer Caroline Herschel in 1783. Close by is globular cluster NGC 288, discovered by her brother William Herschel in 1785.



△ NGC 253

The largest and brightest of the Sculptor Group, this spiral galaxy is 11 million light-years away but at magnitude 7.5 appears as a fuzzy oval in binoculars. It is classed as a starburst galaxy due to its high rate of star formation.

▷ NGC 300

A spiral galaxy with a poorly defined core and diffuse arms, NGC 300 is close to us at just 6 million light-years away, and probably lies between us and the Sculptor Group.



KEY DATA

Size ranking 36

Brightest stars Alpha (α)
4.3, Beta (β) 4.4

Genitive Sculptoris

Abbreviation Scl

Highest in sky at 10pm
October–November

Fully visible 50°N–90°S

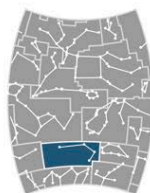


CHART 3

MAIN STARS

Alpha (α) Sculptoris

Blue-white giant star

☼ 4.3 ↔ 776 light-years

Beta (β) Sculptoris

Blue-white subgiant

☼ 4.4 ↔ 174 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

NGC 55

Irrregular galaxy

NGC 253

Spiral galaxy in the Sculptor Group

NGC 288

Globular cluster

NGC 300

Spiral galaxy

NGC 7793

Spiral galaxy in the Sculptor Group

ESO 350-40 (Cartwheel Galaxy)

Combined spiral and ring galaxy

